

Department of Political Science, Yale University

Field Examination in Comparative Politics

August 24, 2015

INSTRUCTIONS: This is a closed book, closed notes exam, with access to a clean copy of the reading list only. You are required to answer 3 questions (each answer comprises one-third of the exam grade). The exam has a strict 21 page limit (double-space, 12 font). You have 7 hours.

1. In *Social Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy*, Barrington Moore, Jr., famously wrote, “no bourgeoisie, no democracy.” How has Moore’s dictum held up, in light of recent research? If you had to summarize recent research with a modification of Moore’s dictum or dicta, what would they be? Which central causes of democratization, identified and argued about in the comparative politics literature, do you find most and least persuasive? Why?
2. The factors of production land, labor, and capital are usually heterogeneous within countries, so there are sectoral differences within as well as between political actors defending and promoting their economic and derived interests. Discuss the role of specific sectoral interests in state formation and other aspects of comparative political development.
3. International wars are thought to influence many features of domestic politics, including state capacity and regime change. Discuss the comparative politics literature that treats war as an independent variable.
4. What is the effect of democratization on political violence—theoretically as well as empirically?
5. Karl Deutsch famously suggested that nationalism (as an ideology and political movement) and the nation state (as the core territorial unit of the international system) emerged and became dominant primarily because of changes in the nature of mass communication. Are similar changes taking place now threatening this dominance? How, and with what implications?
6. In *Polyarchy*, Robert Dahl introduced a novel theory about how different “paths to polyarchy” influenced how democratic regimes perform, especially with regard to regime stability. With his as a starting point, discuss likely “path dependent” aspects of a sample of democratic countries whose institutional evolution you have some familiarity with. In addition to stability, you may wish to discuss other performance aspects or behavior including economic, distributional, international, and military.